How Mom's Care Needs May Change, and What Your Family Can Get Ready Now

A short guide to how needs tend to change, the kinds of care that exist, and what a family can write down while there is time.

The changes come a little at a time: a ride to an appointment, a hand with the bills, a neighbor who checks in. From inside it, the whole picture is hard to see.

This guide explains, in general terms, how an older parent's needs can change and what kinds of care exist, so the words make sense when you hear them. It explains. It doesn't say what Mom will need.

Needs tend to change a little at a time

Changes in mobility, memory, health and independence often develop gradually. A family can live alongside them for a long while without quite seeing them.

Long-term care, the federal Administration for Community Living says, is a range of services and supports a person may need to meet personal care needs. Most of it is not medical care. It is help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life, sometimes called activities of daily living: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

A second group, sometimes called instrumental activities of daily living, covers everyday tasks such as housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing meals, shopping and using the telephone. [1]

The same agency notes that falls often trigger the onset of a series of growing needs, and that most falls can be prevented. [2]

- For each of those tasks, the useful note is what Mom does on her own, what she does with a hand, and who gives it.
- Date the page. A description of this month is something to compare against later.

Ordinary aging, or something more?

This is the question families get stuck on, and for the most part it isn't theirs to answer. On memory, MedlinePlus says that as people grow older it may take longer to remember things, and that it's normal to forget things once in a while. It also says that forgetting how to use the phone or find the way home may be signs of a more serious problem, and that a person who is worried about her forgetfulness should see her health care provider. [3]

On walking and balance, the Administration for Community Living suggests asking an older loved one whether she is concerned about falling, and noticing whether she holds onto walls, furniture or someone else when walking, or has difficulty getting up from a chair. If she is concerned about falling, dizziness or balance, it suggests she discuss it with her health care provider, who can assess her risk. [2]

For most other changes there is no general line to give you. It depends on Mom, and the person who can say is a clinician who knows her. What the family can do is describe what it saw, with the date.

The kinds of care that exist

Long-term care can be provided at home, in the community, or in a facility, and most of it is provided at home. Care at home may come from unpaid family members and friends, or from a nurse, a home health or home care aide, or a therapist who comes to the home. Community services such as adult day care centers and transportation services can add to the care given at home. [1] [4]

Assisted living, MedlinePlus says, is housing and services for people who need some help with daily care, such as dressing, bathing, taking their medicines and cleaning, but who do not need the medical care that a nursing home provides. [5]

Nursing homes provide the most comprehensive range of services, including nursing care and around-the-clock supervision. In hospice care, Medicare's booklet says, the focus is on comfort, not on curing an illness. [4] [6]

You will also hear “memory care.” None of the sources below defines it, so ask any provider who uses the term what it includes there.

For many people, the Administration for Community Living says, a blended approach works best. Which kind of care fits a person, and when, depends on her needs, the state she lives in and the providers near her. That is a question for the clinicians who assess her and for the providers themselves. A guide can't answer it. [4]

What care costs, in general terms

The cost of long-term care depends on the type and duration of care a person needs, the provider, and where she lives. That is as far as a general guide can honestly go. A figure that would mean anything for Mom comes from the providers near her. [7]

Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term care in a nursing home, and it does not pay for non-skilled help with activities of daily living, which make up the majority of long-term care services. [8] [9]

Medicaid is a joint federal and state program that helps some people pay for health care, including long-term care in nursing homes and at home. Its eligibility rules and the services it covers vary from state to state. [10]

Long-term care insurance can help pay for many types of long-term care, and policies vary widely. If Mom has a policy, the insurance company can say what it covers. [8]

- Worth noting now: whether Mom has a long-term care insurance policy, and where it is kept.
- How care might be paid for in your state, and for your family, is a question for your Medicaid planner. This guide doesn't try to answer it.

What this means for your family

- The most useful thing to make now is a dated description of how Mom is doing today and the help she already has.
- What she wants is part of the picture, and only she can say it. The Administration for Community Living notes that most people prefer to remain in their homes for as long as possible, but that is a general observation, not her answer. Ask her, and write down what she says in her own words.
- Learning the words for the kinds of care is enough for now. Choosing among them isn't a decision for today.
- The questions you can't answer by watching, or by asking her, go to her doctor, her pharmacist, local care providers or your Medicaid planner.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't predict how Mom's needs will change, say whether she is safe at home, or tell you which kind of care fits her or what it would cost. It isn't medical, legal, financial or tax advice. The definitions and the general statements come from the sources below. The advice about what to write down is ours.

Ready for the next step?

You can see how needs tend to change, and you know what the words for care mean. The care interview asks about each of those areas for Mom in particular, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Avoiding a Fall
3. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Memory | MedlinePlus
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Assisted Living: MedlinePlus
6. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Medicare Hospice Benefits
7. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Costs of Care
8. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
9. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Planning Ahead After Age 65
10. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid